

Episode 27: Special Episode – My Personal Best Theatrical Anime This Summer

This series has actually exceeded 26 episodes. In TV terms, that's 2 cours! Though I've taken breaks occasionally, man, this is wonderful. I'm amazed at myself (laughs).

So this week I'm setting aside the *Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth* (真紅の少年伝説) story for a "special episode" - before I forget, let me talk about the anime movies I saw this summer.

Lots of anime movies were released this summer. I saw three: *Ratatouille*, *Vexille*, and *Summer Days with Coo* (河童のクウと夏休み). Ah, I really wanted to see many more, but finding time to go...

Well then.

First, *Ratatouille*.

A Disney anime with a mouse protagonist who isn't Mickey (laughs). American animated movies now mean 3DCG. 3DCG means Pixar. Man, amazing. "They can do this much now!" - just pure amazement.

The mouse fur texture - if they made it too realistic it would probably be disgusting. But they pursued realism while properly creating anime-like texture. That balance was great.

And beyond the mouse fur, what really impressed me were the dishes on screen! They really looked delicious. Sure, with a restaurant setting the food should look tasty, but this was the first time I got so excited about both ingredients and finished dishes.

Pleasant layouts and lighting mastery, enjoyable pacing and movement with good editing. And above all, magnificent screenplay. Above all, movies start with screenplay! I really felt it was carefully crafted over time.

My previous American animated movie best #1 was tied between *Monsters, Inc.* and *Mr. Incredible* - but now this *Ratatouille* proudly joins them in a three-way tie.

Next, *Vexille*.

This was also hardcore 3DCG anime. However, unlike *Ratatouille*, this used cel shading for character processing, making it somewhat "anime-like" - you could feel the 2D anime taste we create.

This was also amazing. A movie with lots of mechanical depictions, and this too had that "they can do this much now!" feeling (laughs). A different direction of realism from *Ratatouille*.

The editing and camerawork were very live-action movie-like, which was interesting too. Quite thrilling! A pretty well-made movie.

However, what felt subtle was the matching between "story" and "technique."

This movie is about "humans" and "androids," but both androids and human characters are the same cel-shaded CG on screen. The more realistically gestures and movements were done, the less convincing it felt when those characters spoke about "humanity." Like wanting to yell at the screen "But you're CG!" If it had been regular 2D hand-drawn animation, there wouldn't have been such discomfort. "Maybe this is the difficult part of CG movies?" - that's my impression.

Whether *Ratatouille* or *Vexille*, 3DCG work colours must be difficult. Lighting completely changes how things look. But it's probably fun too, though it looks tough (bitter laugh). If I get a chance someday, I'd definitely like to try it.

And *Summer Days with Coo*.

This is so-called "regular anime" movie like what we make.

"Wow, I got owned!" was my honest impression. Man, I was beautifully made to cry (bitter laugh). Haven't cried at a movie since Director Hosoda (細田)'s *The Girl Who Leapt Through Time* (時をかける少女). In summer vacation with an audience full of children, an old man crying is questionable... but man, I got owned.

Everything was made normally. Nothing particularly special was done. The animation wasn't spectacularly amazing. But it felt like work carefully, truly painstakingly and lovingly crafted. The elementary student protagonist Koichi (康一)'s feelings, those emotions, or the frustrating inadequacy of insufficient feelings - all made so gently. I somehow remembered making *Ojamajo Doremi* (おジャ魔女どれみ).

Truly a movie that leaves proper "good things" in everyone who watches - whether small children or old men like us. Anyway, this *Summer Days with Coo* is my top pick!

Those were my impressions of the three movies I saw this summer. Anime really is great!

By the way, though not anime, I also saw the movie "Transformers." Man, this was fun in its own way. Despite incredibly amazing visuals, the "extremely local feeling alien invasion" was GOOD (laughs).

Just having it transform, stand up, and say "I am Optimus Prime" (in English) was already the best! For us who made the anime version as collaborative work, it's "Optimus Prime," not "Convoy (コンボイ)" (laughs).

But man, magnificent transformation! Transformation scenes that should have been possible only through "anime lies" going "shaki-shaki-shakin!" so naturally - the world really is anything-goes now (laughs).

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